From prototype to a system Desert Rose can run on

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THE RECOMMENDATION

Build our own system on top of the prototype, with a development partner, and keep the Excellence Gateway in Power BI. Before we commit, run a short, fair test of the two best alternatives, because the choice locks us in for years.

Why not simply buy a tool?

We looked at the main hotel and audit apps, and none of them could be confirmed to run fully in Arabic, right to left. SafetyCulture, GoAudits and HotSOS list no Arabic interface at all. hotelkit and Flexkeeping machine-translate the content, but the buttons and menus stay in English. Most of our line staff read Arabic far better than English, so I think that alone rules them out as the main tool.

The regional products we found are mostly hotel PMS or ERP systems, which would mean replacing Opera. That's a much bigger decision than this project needs.

Why build, and what we'd test against it

The prototype already shows the full Arabic app working, with our own rules (safety first, nobody confirms their own fix, overdue happens on its own). Roughly a third to half of the visible app carries over. What's missing is everything behind it: a server, sign-in, shared data and safe syncing.

The two alternatives worth a fair test are low-code platforms with Arabic built in: **Microsoft Power Apps**, because we already run the Gateway on Power BI, and **Zoho Creator**, which documents a mirrored right-to-left layout. Page 2 has the detail.

~14 months

From a yes to the whole resort live. The first two departments go live in about 6 months.

USD 60–150k

First-year build with a regional partner, before devices and Wi-Fi. A guess until partners quote.

3 gates

Route chosen, go-live in two departments, and rollout to the rest. Leadership decides at each one.

1 owner

One system owner in OE, with the authority to say no to scope creep.

What success looks like after year one

- Every department runs its shift checklists and problems in the app, in Arabic or English.
- Overdue problems and repeated audit findings are clearly down against today's baseline.
- No safety problem sits open without a temporary measure and an owner.
- The Morning Briefing runs on live numbers, and nobody retypes data into spreadsheets.

Decisions we need now

- A budget range for year one, and whether a yearly running cost is acceptable.
- Who in OE owns the system, and who on the leadership side signs off at each gate.
- Permission to approach two or three development partners and run the comparison on page 2.
- A target date. I'd aim for two departments live before the summer peak of 2027.

The options, tested against what matters most

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OPTION	FULL ARABIC, RIGHT TO LEFT	WORKS OFFLINE	OUR RULES	FITS POWER BI	COST SHAPE	OWNERSHIP
Custom build on the prototype Our own app, built by a partner	Yes, already proven	To build properly	Exactly ours	Direct	Build cost plus yearly upkeep	We own it
Microsoft Power Apps Low-code, built by a Microsoft partner	Partly. RTL is documented for some page types; canvas apps need care, and one known mirroring issue on Windows	Yes, but only in the Power Apps mobile app, with Dataverse	Mostly configurable	Native	About USD 10–20 per user per month, plus the build	Tied to Microsoft
Zoho Creator Low-code, built by a Zoho partner	Documented: mirrored RTL layout for Arabic	Not confirmed	Mostly configurable	Through export or API	Per-user subscription, plus the build	Tied to Zoho
Odoo (Maintenance, Quality) Open-source ERP, partner-built	RTL since version 12	Not confirmed	Needs customising	Through API	Hosting and partner time	Open source
SafetyCulture, GoAudits Global audit apps	No Arabic interface listed	Strong	Partly	Through API	Per-user subscription	Vendor
hotelkit, Flexkeeping Hotel operations apps	Machine translation only	Partly	Partly	Through API	Per-user or per-room	Vendor
Amadeus HotSOS Hotel service and maintenance	Mobile app in English only	Partly	Partly	Through API	Enterprise licence	Vendor
Regional Arabic-first products Mostly PMS and ERP, e.g. Frontdesko	Arabic-first	Not confirmed	Would replace Opera	Unknown	Varies	Vendor

Power Apps, checked properly

- Offline works only in the native Power Apps mobile app (not a browser) and only with Dataverse data, with some limits on filters and relationships.
- Microsoft documents RTL for Arabic on some page types. For canvas apps, users report a mirrored layout on the Windows app and say there is no reliable fix yet. Phones need a real test.
- Licences are per named user: Premium is about USD 20 a month, or about USD 10 per active user per app on pay-as-you-go. Shared team phones need checking against the licence terms.

The comparison test (2–3 weeks)

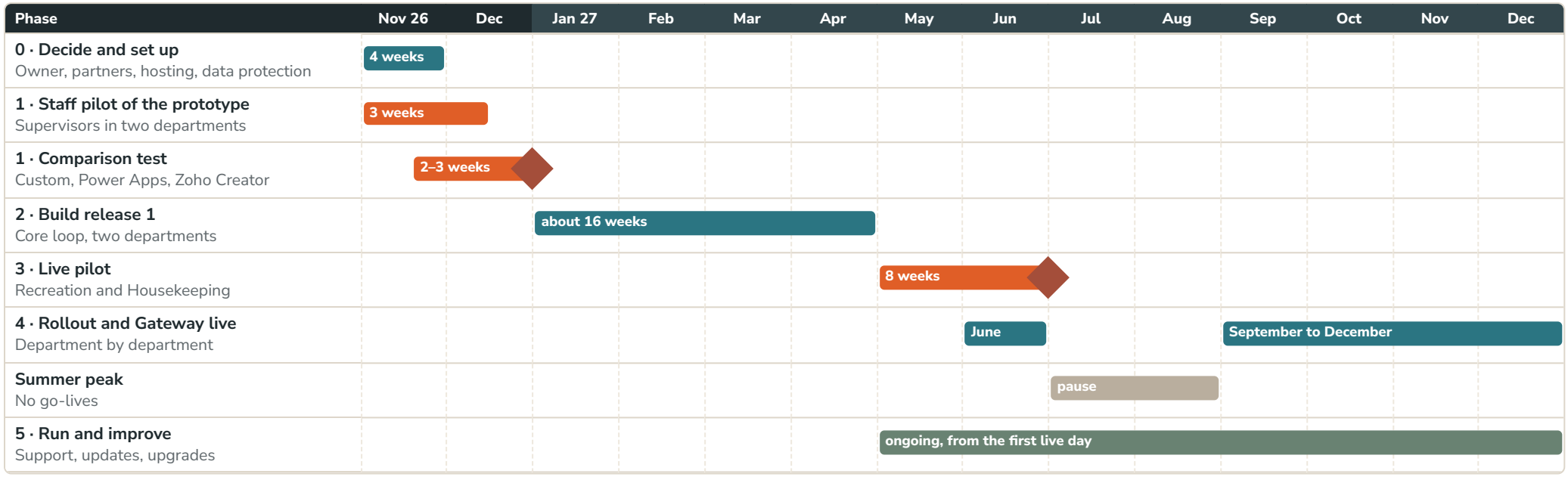
Each shortlisted route builds the same small slice: the pool opening checklist, one problem reported with a photo, assigned, fixed and confirmed by someone else, all in Arabic, on a phone, at the beach with weak Wi-Fi. We score Arabic, offline, speed for staff, our rules, cost over 3 years, and who owns the result. Custom build, Power Apps and Zoho Creator go into the test.

How sure are we?

Everything in this table comes from public product pages and help centres, checked on 11 October 2026. Vendors often have more than they publish, so each one gets the same written questions and a live test before we rule anything in or out. Sources are listed on page 6.

The plan on one page

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GATE 1 · MID-DECEMBER

Leadership picks the route from the comparison test and approves the release 1 budget and must-have list.

GATE 2 · END OF MAY

Go or no-go for rollout, based on the live pilot: do supervisors use it every shift, and are overdue problems and repeated findings going down?

GATE 3 · EACH MONTH FROM JUNE

Each new department goes live only when devices, Wi-Fi, checklists and training are ready. One or two at a time, with no go-lives in July and August.

Dates assume a yes in early November 2026. If the start moves, the plan moves with it. The summer peak is the one window I'd avoid for any go-live.

What happens in each phase

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0 Decide and set up — 4 weeks

- Name the system owner in OE and a sponsor in leadership.
- Shortlist 2–3 development partners (an Egyptian agency keeps cost and time zone right).
- Contract terms: we own the code, data and documentation; a second firm can take over.
- Hosting on Azure (we already use Microsoft) and a data-protection check under Law 151.

Done when: Owner named, partners shortlisted, contract terms agreed.

1 Staff pilot and comparison test — 3–4 weeks

- Supervisors use the prototype for real in Recreation and Housekeeping.
- We write the fixed must-have list for release 1 from what they actually use.
- Run the comparison test on page 2 and score the results.

Done when: Must-have list, scored comparison, Gate 1 decision.

2 Build release 1 — about 16 weeks

- Sign-in by role; shared phones use a PIN or badge.
- Central database, photo store, and a full record of who did what and when.
- Offline syncing that copes with two people changing the same problem.
- An admin screen so OE changes checklists without a developer.
- Alerts for safety and overdue problems (badge, push or WhatsApp).
- Security test, automatic backups, uptime monitoring.

Done when: Release 1 tested on real devices at the pool, beach and back-of-house.

3 Live pilot — 8 weeks

- Recreation and Housekeeping run on the new system, with paper as a backup for the first weeks.
- Weekly fixes; measure against today: overdue problems, repeated findings, days to fix.

Done when: Pilot report and Gate 2 decision.

4 Rollout and Gateway live — June, then Sep–Dec

- One or two departments a month, each with its own checklists and training. No go-lives in the July and August peak.
- Data flows into Power BI, so the Morning Briefing runs on live numbers.
- Then the outside links, one at a time: Exclusivi, TrustYou, and later Opera.

Done when: Whole resort live; Morning Briefing on live data.

5 Run and improve — ongoing

- A clear first contact for problems, with fast cover in high season.
- Monthly updates and a short upgrade list owned by OE.
- A yearly review of cost, use and what to improve next.

Done when: A system that keeps getting better instead of drifting.

Team, budget and what keeps it running

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Team

System owner (OE)	Decides scope, priorities and checklists. Part-time but real.
Sponsor (leadership)	Signs off at each gate and clears blockers.
Partner: tech lead	Architecture, security, quality.
Partner: 2 developers	Build, sync, integrations.
Tester and designer	Part-time, during the build.
Champions	One supervisor per department who helps colleagues and reports problems.
After launch	1–2 people for support and updates, through the partner or in-house.

Budget (to be confirmed by quotes)

Build, year one	USD 60,000–150,000 with a regional partner
Hosting	About USD 300–1,500 a month
Upkeep	About 15–25% of the build cost each year
Devices	Shared, rugged phones per team. Number and model set during phase 1
Wi-Fi	A coverage survey of pools, beach and back-of-house, then fixes
If Power Apps wins	Build cost plus about USD 10–20 per user per month

These are my estimates to frame the conversation, not quotes. Partners quote against the must-have list in phase 1.

What makes it robust

- **Works offline,** and syncs safely when the signal comes back.
- **Wi-Fi where the work happens,** not only in offices.
- **Devices with a home:** charged, shared by team, stored in one place between shifts.
- **One owner** who changes settings; departments don't change them alone.
- **Backups, monitoring and a support line** that answers at 7am in August.
- **Data protection:** clear rules on who sees staff names and photos, and where data is stored.
- **Upgradable by design:** open API, full data export, and checklists changed by OE, not by code.

Risks, the next 30 days, and sources

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Main risks

RISK	LEVEL	HOW WE HANDLE IT
Depending on one partner or one developer	Medium	We own the code; documentation and automated tests are part of the contract; a second firm can take over.
Scope keeps growing	High	Release 1 is two departments and the core loop only. Everything else waits for the gates.
Offline syncing is harder than expected	Medium	Build and test it first, in the real places, before anything else.
Staff don't use it every shift	Medium	Supervisors help shape it in phase 1; champions per department; the first weeks get extra support.
Wi-Fi and devices aren't ready	Medium	Survey in phase 0; no department goes live without them (Gate 3).
Power Apps or Zoho look cheaper now, cost more later	Medium	Compare cost over 3 years and check the licence terms for shared phones.

The next 30 days

1. Leadership agrees the route in principle, a budget range and the system owner.
2. Book the staff pilot of the prototype with Recreation and Housekeeping supervisors.
3. Send the same written questions to 2–3 development partners, a Microsoft partner and a Zoho partner.
4. Survey Wi-Fi at the pools, beach and back-of-house.
5. Agree the comparison test and how we score it.

By early December we'll know which route to take, what it costs and when the first two departments go live.

Sources (checked 11 October 2026)

- SafetyCulture supported languages: https://help.safetyculture.com/003515
- SafetyCulture multi-language templates: https://help.safetyculture.com/001214
- hotelkit spring 2025 update: https://hotelkit.net/blog/up2date-with-hotelkit-spring-edition-2025/
- Flexkeeping FAQ: https://help.flexkeeping.com/en/support/solutions/articles/103000328819-most-frequently-asked-questions
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- HotSOS Mobile, App Store: https://apps.apple.com/app/id704551252
- GoAudits mobile app: https://goaudits.com/app/new/
- Power Apps offline limits (Microsoft Learn): https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-apps/mobile/limitations-canvas-apps
- Power Apps RTL on custom pages (Microsoft Learn): https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-apps/maker/model-driven-apps/custom-page-localize
- Power Apps RTL mirroring issue (community): https://community.powerplatform.com/forums/thread/details/?threadid=ea791bb1-a84d-f011-877a-0022482a97fb
- Power Apps pricing 2026 (third party): https://www.superblocks.com/blog/powerapps-pricing
- Zoho Creator localization and RTL: https://help.zoho.com/portal/en/kb/creator/developer-guide/application-settings/localization/articles/understand-localization
- Odoo Arabic UI (partner article): https://www.braincuber.com/blog/is-your-business-ready-odoo-arabic-ui-2026
- Saudi hotel software list: https://www.softwaresuggest.com/hotel-management-software/sa